UNDERSTANDING CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY AND THE RELATED NOTIONS OF CULTURE

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The paper presents some ideas concerning the possibilities of the contribution of cultural anthropology to the understanding of the processes of social reconstruction after the collapse of socialism in Eastern Europe. By doing this, it also introduces the interested reader in some aspects of the theoretical background of the cultural anthropology program as it is developed at the Faculty of European Studies, Babes-Bolyai University. Concerning the institutional framework of this program has to be mentioned, that at present — started with the academic year 1966/1997 — this takes the form of a two-semester long M. A. studies, involving ten students graduated in different social sciences. Presenting some aspects of the theoretical/conceptual basis of our new intellectual/institutional enterprise the paper actually reflects on how this wants to localise itself in the framework of the redefined European ethnology and of cultural anthropology as the discipline that studies complex societies at home and/or abroad.

Today in Eastern Europe the attempt of *understanding cultural anthropology* means to define it as a newly institutionalised discipline that can make a great contribution to the investigation of *the cultural dimension of the contemporary social, economic and political processes.*

In my paper I will make a reflection on the notion of culture that, of course, is used as an important theoretical and methodological tool in the anthropological inquiry. I will define some possible directions in which this discipline, as a cultural approach, can produce results in *the understanding of the reconstruction of social realities after the collapse of socialism.*

The cultural encounters between Eastern and Western European societies; the *differences constructed* and maintained between and inside of the societies of our region; *the processes of cultural sharing and diversity* as they function in these countries in the context of the ethnicised and engendered social relationships — there are *some of the main issues* that can be analysed in concrete situations and through particular case studies by the means of the qualitative anthropological inquiry.

As *native researcher* — using concrete empirical materials, respectively a knowledge about their historical and contemporary social/political context, and making a permanent critical reflection on the condition of the insider — one can have *a contribution to the production of critical theories about the contemporary Eastern European transitions.* This is because the perspective of cultural antropology — defined as *an interpretative, reflexive and critical cultural analysis of cultural sharing and cultural diversity* — is able to elaborate a critics of dominant discourses and to deconstruct some naturalised Grand Narratives (but also some binary oppositions between different homogenised "us" and "them"). I am referring between others to *the dominant discourses and the narratives of national and gender identities*

that in the way as they function today *after the collapse of socialism* — by inventing "traditions" as natural givens and through the politicisation of the desire of belonging and of recognition — *are among the main cultural impediments of the changes of mentalities.* (On the critical dimension of cultural anthropology see for example D. H. Hymes, 1972; B. Scholte, 1972; G. E. Marcus and M. M. J. Fischer, 1986; R. C. Ulin, 1991, C. West, 1994.)

Because cultural anthropology *as the cultural analysis of everyday life asks how life is experienced and expressed by different people* (who occupies different social positions and have different perspectives on what's happening) — after the collapse of the socialist ideology and in the conditions of the rebirth of other kind of homogenising images on reality —, it can rehabilitate the different, the small stories and the marginal experiences. In this way it becomes a discipline that *describes and interprets the social conditions of cultural sharing and cultural diversity.* (On the anthropology of everyday life see for example O. Löfgren, 1990; J. Frykman, 1989; P. Niedermüller, 1993).

Arguing the cultural anthropology's contribution to the understanding of contemporary transitions, one can further emphasise that it can *interpret the processes of the (re)construction of reality, mainly those performed by symbolic forms* in concrete spatio-temporal contexts, through the activities of different social actors (individuals and communities).

Doing this, the anthropological analysis aims to understand *how different phenomena* (as rituals, habits, objects, social relations, behaviours, institutions, written texts and so on) *"read" by the researcher as cultural forms represent cultural contents, that is cultural meanings and categories* produced and shared by different groups of people in certain social contexts and historical moments. As such it offers an interpretative "explanation" of the meanings that are relevant from the point of view of the participants, — that is — it constructs the links between the observed activities, events, behaviours (as texts) and their meanings (On the nature of the interpretative analysis see C. Geertz, 1973, 1983).

Analysing complex and contemporary societies, cultural anthropology understood in this manner is interested in *the social organisation of meanings* (see U. Hannerz, 1992), emphasises *the dialectics between cultural sharing and diversity* (see M. Gullestad, 1991), and *the practice of constructing cultures* (see S. Ortner, 1994; P. Bourdieu, 1973). By this it becomes *the discipline of cultural differences,* that can study the means and strategies through which today in Eastern Europe different identities are redefined, social boundaries inside and between countries are constructed.

In the next part of the paper I would like to reflect on *the notion of culture as a theoretical and methodological tool.* So my following questions are related on the one hand to *its content* and on the other hand to the nature of the *cultural approach.* Of course, these two aspects are connected, so at the very beginning I can mention that the following reflections on them are not part of a "culturalist" perspective

on culture and on cultural approach. But are related to a *version of the interpretative paradigm: that one which — in the definition of the "cultural" — emphasises the links between society, culture and politics, and the practice of culture-building,* respectively asks about *the social, cultural and political functions of symbolic forms through which individuals as members of certain social groups construct/understand their world;* and it searches *the way how power relations are built/challenged/ maintained through symbolical battles performed on the "proper" meanings of reality.*

It is obvious by now that in what follows I use the notion of culture first of all instrumentally in order to define the nature of the anthropological *cultural approach,* and only related to this I will mention briefly some relevant meanings of the notion of "culture".

In my mind this approach is located in the larger frame of the investigation of the researcher's "own society" on empirical basis: as *a particular way of understanding the human thinking expressed/produced through socially constructed symbolic forms; as a certain way of interpreting the social, cultural and political dimensions of the practices and the lived experiences of everyday life as they are functoning in complex societies.* In the following paragraphs — as a result of the effort to combine the interpretative and the political economy perspective and the conceptalisation of complex societies as a network of perspectives — I would like to present first of all one possible understanding of cultural approach, and only related to this some meanings of the notion of culture.

It is well-known that since the 1960s anthropology started to move its focus from social structures and human behaviour to *the socially contsructed meanings and intersubjectively formed ways of thinking.* One of the main changes that went on in this discipline were performed by *the interpretative turn*; a perspective that — in the context of the crises of representation in social sciences — elaborated a critics of the traditional myth of fieldwork and practices of writing. It redefined the possibilities and limits of the anthropological understanging and those of the researcher, respectively the position of the personal accounts in the anthropological texts, emphasising their self-reflexive features; it introduced in the anthropological discourse topics like textualisation, representation, discourse and discussions about the epistemological dimension of the anthropological knowledge (see for example J. Clifford and G.E. Marcus, 1986; J. Clifford, 1983).

In the same time, under a Marxist influence, *the political economy paradigm* redefined the importance of holistic approach and focused its attention on *the processes of globalisation and creolisation in the network of the contemporary cultures.* It introduced in the framework of the anthropological analysis *the historical and political perspective,* and the discussion on the *links between the different smaller social, national and their larger international context* (see for example E. Wolf, 1990). The focus of the interest turned to these topics generated methodological redefinitions, too: as a result, anthropology became opened towards the *interdisciplinary researches,* mainly to the attempts ori-

entated to *the reconstruction of the historical background of the contemporary processes, to the identification of the patterns of the using of the past, of the models of its representation in contemporary narratives* and others. Issues like *how national identities and national cultures are built* during history, how they become the symbolical battlegrounds of the political discourses, how power constructs/ maintains/ challenges certain meanings while being legitimated/ challenged by them — there are some of the questions that began to be "conquered" by the anthoropological analysis, too (see for example E. Wolf, 1990). Related to this, culture was not saw any more as a reproduction of uniformity but rather as an organisation of diversity.

The way how *the relationship between cultural and political* was shaped as an anthropological topic, respectively how *the promise of the critical attitude* was formed are also the results of the encounters between anthropology and "cultural studies". The common points of these approaches are the questions concerning *the processes of cultural differentiation in the contemporary societies, the cultural dimension of the social inequalities, the everyday life as it is lived by people;* they are related to *the representation of reality in peripheral cultures,* to *the means and strategies through which the dominant cultures define the "legitimate" interpretations of reality* and through which *individuals are constructed as social subjects* (see for example, V. Blundell — J. Sheperd — I. Taylor, 1993; S. During, 1994).

On the basis of the above briefly presented directions of contemporary cultural anthropology, I suggest that in the present-day. East-European context one could understand and institutionalise it in the following meanings:

1. Anthropology is *a form of cultural analysis* that aims to understand human thinking, as it is expressed, and even produced through inter-subiectively constructed symbolic forms. The investigation is realised in the frameworks of concrete microanalyses, and aims to construct the links between the cultural forms that are observable from outside and the cultural contents that are represented/ produced through them. So *the anthropology of thinking* is the research of *the means and strategies of how members of a group construct, use, organise their symbolical forms of self-expression, of how they define and demarcate their identity*; it also contains *the description of the social context* in which all this happens; it tends to *identify the meanings that are relevant from the point of view of the participants*; and, through all these, it offers an empirically and theoretically based interpretation on how cultural meanings are connected to cultural forms in particular social/ historical/ political contexts. Of course, all the mentioned aims are relevant in the perspective that defines thinking as a social and symbolic activity; and considers *culture as a symbolic construction,* as the totality of the links between cultural forms and contents: as *the system of the historically shaped patterns of meanings by which people communicate, express their identity and their sense of belonging* (see C. Geertz, 1973, 1983). The cultural analysis in these terms, as *a symbolical approach,* means not simply the study of some signs that are considered

in the researched community as "symbols". But rather it is identified with the qualitative interrogation of any kind of social, economic and political activity, institution, ritual etc. through *questions related to their cultural dimensions,* to the meanings, images, ideas, feelings represented by them.

2. If one emphasises *the processual and constructed nature of culture,* its constitutive and constituted character, then can define the anthropological cultural analysis as *the anthropology of practice.* As such it makes *the investigation of the practices through which reality is built* by cultural, symbolical means and those by which, at its turn, culture is constructed through everything that real people do in real settings.

This approach introduces in the anthropological discourse terms like activity, cultural change, processes, cultural hegemony and so on. In particular ways *it links the historical and the anthropological perspective,* asking how internal and external processes shape the life of a social group, how social integration and disintegration is expressed/ represented/ produced by symbolic means, *how the social is constructed by individual practice and the latter is constrained by the former* (see for example S. Ortner, 1994; P. Bourdieu, 1973).

The reflection on the relationship between practice and system focuses the attention on the analysis of those cultural mechanism that govern people's consciousness, the ways they perceive, define themselves: so topics like *symbolic power* and *discourse* (see M. Foucault, 1981) become central, and the political dimension of any kind of social relationship and of the production of meanings starts to be enlightened. It is supposed that the social and the cultural are inseparable linked aspects of human life, and *culture is a social practice,* more precisely, *the symbolical dimension of the human practice, the practice of symbolisation, the totality of means and strategies that construct shared, but also differentiated meanings* (see for example R. Bocock, 1995).

3. The anthropology of practice is intertwined with *the cultural analysis of everyday life,* that focuses on *the lived experiences* and *the cultural meanings relevant in the lifeworld of groups and individuals.* "Everyday life" in this context is understood as the interpreted, lived, so as *the subjectively meaningful,* and *taken-for-granted reality;* as *the inter-subjective frame of life* where individuals can communicate because they share a natural attitude, a set of "proper" knowledge concerning themselves and their social reality (see for example P. Berger and T. Luckmann, 1991; A. Schütz, 1984).

Understood in this broader sense, everyday life is not identified with the life of the "people from the street", but is seen from the elite's point of view, too; and, of course, is not the opposite of feasts, or other "special" events, but it contains them as practices governed by different kind of knowledges than the "ordinary" ones.

The over-present nature of everyday life (see O. Löfgren, 1991) makes obvious that by its analysis one can understand and compare the different "normalities" that are accepted as such in the framework

of different social spheres, by different social actors having different perspectives on and experiences of the social reality. So the study of everyday life is also *the study of the social differentiations* that function in complex societies, *of the "over-arching" cultural categories* (see M. Gullestad, 1991) that are constructed in different meanings in the "same" society at the same, and/or at different times.

Finally has to be mentioned, that the analysis of everyday life has another, extraprofessional impact, too: it legitimates and rehabilitates some perspectives that are marginal and hidden, peripheral and non-dominant in particular social and political context. It is one approach that is able to represent on empirical basis how life is lived outside the "official" and political discourses that shape and dominate the public sphere.

This study identified a possible way of understanding cultural anthropology and its contribution to the interpretation of the contemporary reconstructions of the East-European realities. Defined this discipline as *a cultural, critical analysis of thinking and of cultural meanings, of practice and of the cultural mechanisms of power, of everyday life and of the social differentiation of lived experiences.* In a next paper I will reflect on some dilemmas and theoretical aspects of *the anthropology of the complex societies,* respectively of *the researcher's ou n society.*

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